

A new kind of conflict

Improving America's ability to wage conventional war was only part of Kennedy's plan. He wanted specific initiatives devised to deal with guerrilla activity, insurgency, and subversion. Kennedy believed the Army needed to come up with a new strategy, a wholly different kind of force, and a new kind of military training to meet what he considered to be the preeminent threat of the day. His answer was to double the size of US Special Forces. This was only the beginning. Over the next three years, Kennedy issued 23 National Security Action Memorandums with counterinsurgency as their common subject.

Test case

South Vietnam was to be the proving ground for the new strategy. Having seen a clandestine attempt to overthrow Fidel Castro end in disaster at the Bay of Pigs and having backed down from confronting communism in Laos in the interests of US-Soviet cooperation, Kennedy decided that he had to make a stand in Vietnam. Vice President Lyndon Johnson concurred. After visiting Saigon in May 1961, Johnson told the president that he faced a stark choice: meet the challenge of communist expansion or prepare to give up on Southeast Asia.



Democratic team

A campaign button for the 1961 election campaign advertises the original dream ticket, combining the youthful energy of Kennedy and the experience of running mate Lyndon Johnson.